

New Generation English B· Diagnostic Test

B2 (Upper-Intermediate Exam Route) B· Reading

READING

Why students are returning to paper books

For nearly two decades, paper textbooks were widely predicted to disappear from student life. Forecasts in education journals between 2005 and 2015 confidently suggested that by 2025 the average student would carry only a tablet. The reality has been very different. A growing body of research, particularly in Northern Europe and parts of Asia, shows that university students are now actively choosing paper books for serious reading **even** when digital versions are cheaper, lighter and immediately available.

The reasons are not nostalgic. In repeated studies, students who read complex academic texts on paper outperform their peers reading the same texts on screens, especially on tasks that require sustained inference rather than quick fact retrieval. The difference is small for short pieces, but consistent for anything longer than about a thousand words.

Researchers offer several explanations. Paper does not interrupt the reader; it does not buzz, glow, or invite a parallel browser window. It encourages physical landmarks **so** a particular paragraph is remembered as being near the top of a specific page **so** that screens cannot easily replicate. And it discourages the temptation, common among digital natives, to scroll quickly and assume understanding.

This does not amount to a rejection of digital tools. The same students typically use laptops for searches, note-taking and quick reference. What they are doing, instead, is matching the medium to the task: digital for fast and connected work, paper for slow and analytical reading. The interesting question is whether libraries, publishers and even universities themselves will respond by treating this choice as serious **or** continue to assume that the digital future is the only future worth planning for.

1. What did journals between 2005 and 2015 confidently predict?

- A) That paper textbooks would disappear by 2025.**
- B) That tablets would become more expensive.
- C) That universities would close their libraries.

2. What does a growing body of research show?

- A) Students prefer audio books.
- B) Students are actively choosing paper books for serious reading.**
- C) Digital books are universally superior.

3. On what kind of task do paper-readers especially outperform screen-readers?

- A) Quick fact retrieval.
- B) Tasks requiring sustained inference.**
- C) Short news articles.

